tives and vendors alike," says Sureka. Rather than getting her bogged down, she says, it made her stronger and more determined to prove herself. What worked was her consistency and just showing up every day doing what she had to do.

Her experience was not unusual. For an entire generation of women entering family-owned businesses, the first hurdle was often having to justify why they needed to work at all. At best, it was seen as a hobby.

However, a lot has changed in the intervening decades. Building on the path forged by the earlier generations, more women from second and third generations of business families are joining enterprises owned by their parents, contributing significantly to business growth. But while getting a foot in the door may have become easier, earning acceptance and establishing authority in traditionally male-dominated organisations remain challenges.

Gauri Kirloskar, a fifth-generation member of the 138-year-old Kirloskar Group, found that family support did not necessarily translate into acceptance at work. Now Managing Director of Kirloskar Oil Engines, she recalls an investor meeting where a person directed every question at her but avoided making eye contact, choosing instead to look at the CFO seated beside her. "Even with the advantages I had, some biases were just unconscious and did play out," she says.

According to Kirloskar, what made acceptance difficult was also that she took charge of a core engineering business before turning 40 without an engineering degree or the expected tenure. She has since led strategic expansion into newer areas like defence, commissioning a project for the Indian Navy, as well as other engine categories like fuel cells and electrolysers, alongside growing revenues and profitability.

Kirloskar has now turned her focus towards reviving the four listed group companies and put in place an ambitious ₹5,000-crore turnaround plan aimed at doubling Kirloskar Group revenues to $5 billion by 2030. To be sure, there are two different Kirloskar Groups—one

PHOTOS BY **MILIND SHELTE**

"ONE OF THE MOST IMPORTANT LESSONS I HAVE LEARNT IS THAT TRUST CANNOT BE DEMANDED; IT IS EARNED OVER TIME THROUGH JUDGEMENT, CONSISTENCY, AND HOW YOU HANDLE DIFFICULT MOMENTS"

VINITA GUPTA, CEO, LUPIN

- **Established the business in the highly competitive US market; the company is the third-largest generic pharma company in the US**
- **Expanded in Europe**
- **Led transition from generics to more technically complex generics in areas like respiration and inhalation therapies to strengthen competitiveness and profitability**
- **Grew revenues from ₹15,373 crore in FY20 to ₹27,958 crore in FY26. Profitability grew from a net loss of ₹269 crore to profit after tax of ₹5,356 crore**

